own. He passed on the order to the units of the division and immediately informed Pliev's headquarters, where General Grechko neither confirmed nor aborted the order. Whether the actual order originated with Garbuz, as he claimed, or with Voronkov, as suggested by Serovoi, Grechko as the senior officer in charge was now responsible for an order that was in clear violation of Pliev's instructions.[16]

It looked for some time, however, as if the order would have no effect, since precious time had been lost. While Grechko was hesitating about whether or not to shoot down the U-2, it disappeared from the radar screens. But the order remained in force, and a few minutes later, when the U-2 reappeared on radar after making a turn over the eastern tip of the island and proceeding westward, in the direction of Havana, Voronkov's men were ready. At the SAM launch site near the town of Banes, the commander of the SAM battalion, Major Ivan Gerchenov, his chief of staff, Captain Nikolai Antonets, and Lieutenant Aleksei Riapenko crammed into the cabin of the R-12 launcher and followed the target on the radar screen. Antonets, who was maintaining communications with regimental headquarters, asked Gerchenov: "What are we going to do? Shoot?" Antonets asked once for confirmation of the order, then a second time. "Wait, the order will follow any minute," came the answer.[17]

"Destroy the target with a salvo of three!" Lieutenant Riapenko, the launcher's target officer, heard those words in the voice of Major Gerchenov, who had finally got the order confirmed. "I switched all three firing channels to BR mode and pressed the 'Fire' button of the first channel," recalled Riapenko. "The missile took off from the launch pad. Then I reported: 'Target locked in!' The first missile had already been in flight for nine or ten seconds when the commander ordered: 'Fire two!' I pressed the 'Fire' button of the second channel. When the first missile exploded, a cloud appeared on the screens. I reported: 'One, explosion. Target connected. Target damaged!' After the explosion of the second missile the target abruptly began to lose altitude, and I reported: 'Two, explosion. Target destroyed!' "

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